FOR DECADES, THE MBA PROMISED A SIMPLE BARGAIN. Master management, secure a campus placement and enter the corporate fast track. That bargain has not collapsed, but it is being rewritten. Artificial intelligence can perform tasks once entrusted to freshly minted managers. Employers want skills beyond a degree. Students want to know whether the returns justify the costs.

Warning signs are emerging. Registrations for the Common Admission Test (CAT) fell from 329,000 in 2024 to 295,000 in 2025. In INDIA TODAY's Best B-School survey of 2026, 40 per cent of the top 25 B-schools reported lower admissions. These included four IIMs. Abroad, the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, Arizona State University and Britain's Henley Business School have dropped the full-time two-year MBA. Aswath Damodaran of NYU Stern predicts fewer bankers, consultants and investment managers as AI advances, and consequently fewer takers for management degrees. His prescription is radical. Stop expanding and cut the MBA to one year.

India is not there yet. A degree from a leading B-school costs Rs 20-40 lakh, but corporate demand remains strong. Still, the question of value has become unavoidable. The 14th INDIA TODAY-MDRA survey contacted over 2,000 institutions and ranked 277 on 127 attributes spanning learning, placements, future orientation, campus life and governance. It also examined executive, online, advanced-management and doctoral programmes.

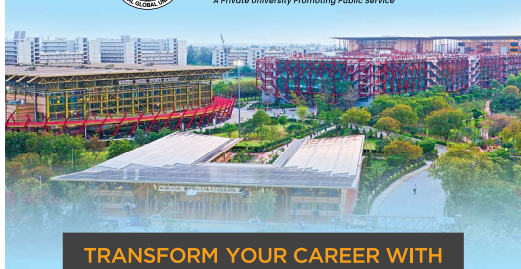
At the top, IIM Ahmedabad retains first place, followed by IIM Calcutta and Lucknow, SPJIMR Mumbai and XLRI Jamshedpur. But familiar rankings conceal divergent fortunes. The top 25's placement rate slipped from 97.5 to 96.4 per cent, while that of schools ranked 51-75 rose from 87.4 to 93.8 per cent. Average domestic sala-

TOP 10 B-SCHOOLS OF INDIA

RANK 2026	RANK 2025	RANK 2024	NAME OF THE INSTITUTE	CITY	CATEGORY
1	1	NP	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT AHMEDABAD	Ahmedabad	Government
2	2	1	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT CALCUTTA	Kolkata	Government
3	3	2	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT LUCKNOW	Lucknow	Government
4	4	3	S.P. JAIN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT AND RESEARCH	Mumbai	Private
5	6	NP	XLRI - XAVIER SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT	Jamshedpur	Private
6	5	5	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT INDORE	Indore	Government
7	7	6	MANAGEMENT DEVELOPMENT INSTITUTE GURGAON	Gurugram	Private
8	9	8	SVKM'S NMIMS SCHOOL OF BUSINESS MANAGEMENT	Mumbai	Private
9	8	7	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF FOREIGN TRADE	New Delhi	Government
10	10	9	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT SHILLONG	Shillong	Government

NP: Not Participated

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